

# **Walking Into Money: How Walk Rate Influences MLB Salary**

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# Research Problem & Motivation

## Main Question:

Does walk rate really affect how much players get paid in Major League Baseball?



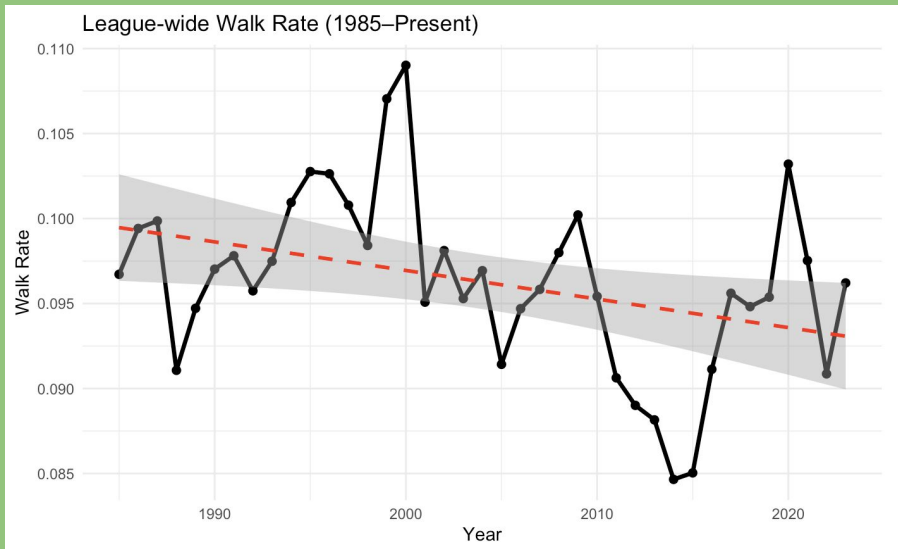
## Definition:

A base on balls (BB), otherwise known as a walk is when a hitter takes 4 balls outside the strike zone before another result occurs.

## Why it matters:

- Walks increase on base percentage (OBP) & run production.
- Pitchers who walk fewer hitters are more efficient.
- Walks are under-discussed in salary negotiations.

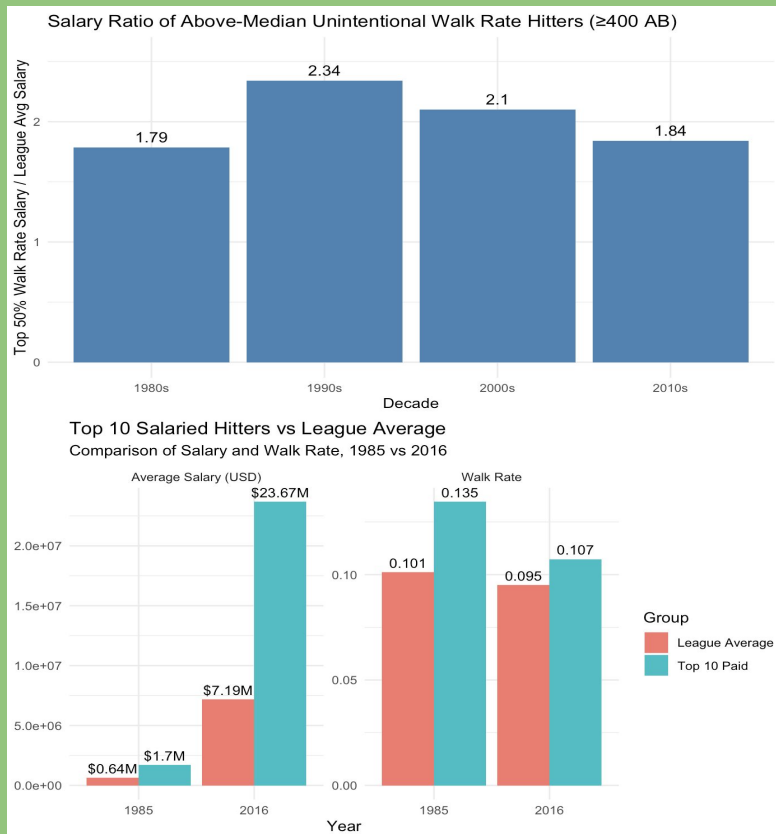
# Historical Walk Trends (Hitters)



All data used from Lahman Baseball Database

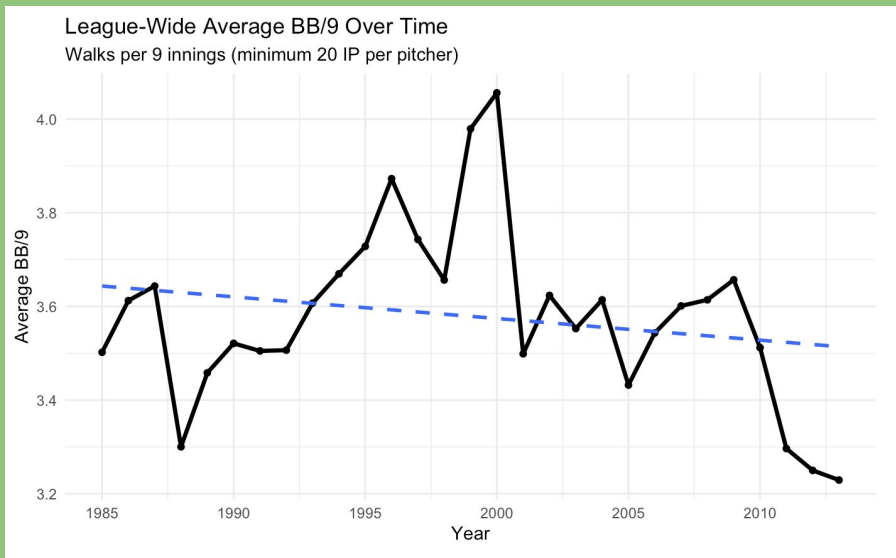
- Overall decline since 1985
- Spike in 1990s and 2000s due to the “steroid era”.
  - A large amount of players were suspected of taking PEDs in the late 90s and early 2000s.
  - Pitchers did not want to give up home runs to these guys so they walked them more often.

# Hitter Salary Comparison



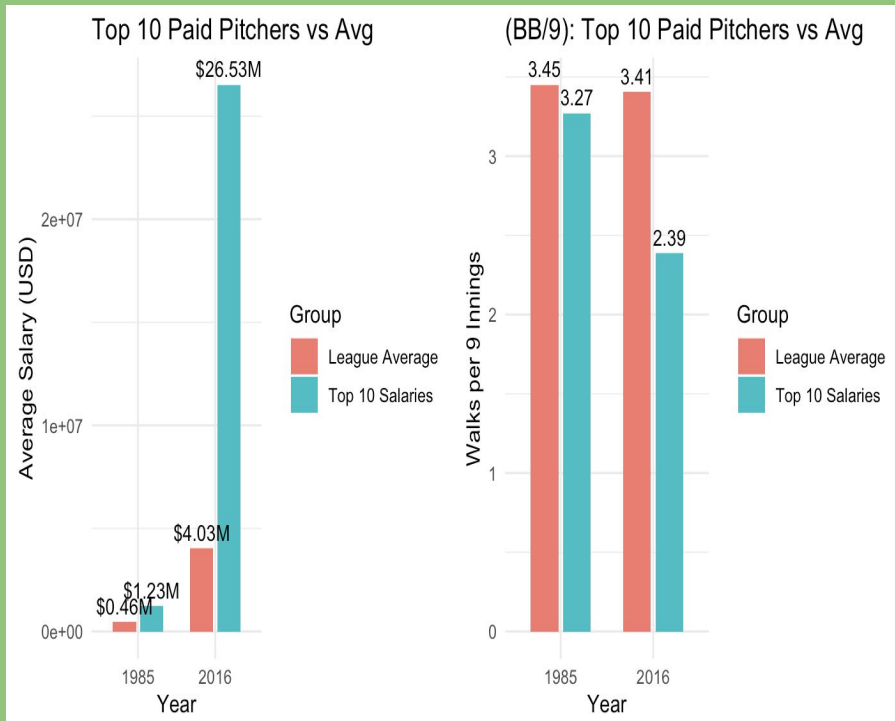
- High-walk hitters consistently earn above league-average salaries.
- Top 10 paid hitters had higher walk rates than league average (1985 & 2016).
- The highest paid hitters in 1985 walked more than in 2016.

# Pitchers & Walk Trends



- **BB/9 is on the decline since 1985.**
  - Again the spike in the late '90s and early '00s is from the steroid era.
- **Most likely due to jumps in velocity, scouting data, and bullpen specialization.**

# Pitcher Salary Comparison



- **1985:** The highest paid pitchers only walked slightly less batters than the league average pitcher.
- **2016:** The highest paid pitchers walked significantly less batters than the average pitcher.
- The average walk rates in 1985 and 2016 are similar.

# Correlation Summary & Interpretation

- **Hitters:** Higher walk rate → higher salary
- **Pitchers:** Lower BB/9 → much higher salary

## Why?

- Walks influence OBP and OPS greatly, which are driving factors in negotiations (especially OPS).
- Pitchers who walk less people allow less baserunners and therefore gives them less opportunities to allow runs.

# Conclusion & Limitations

## Conclusion:

- Despite not being the most looked at statistic, players who walk more get paid
- Walk rate has clear correlations with salary trends
- Especially strong for pitchers

## Limitations:

- Salary data available only through 2016
  - Due to privacy policies with the MLBPA
- Correlation  $\neq$  causation
- Confounding variables not discussed



**Thank You!**